GitHub Desktop on Windows 11

Simple file uploading, fetching, pulling and cloning - no code editor required.

Tools: GitHub Desktop + Windows File Explorer. Git for Windows can also be installed separately.

Official downloads: desktop.github.com and git-scm.com/install/windows.

Basic workflow

Upload: Add files in File Explorer → review Changes → Commit → Push origin.

Download updates: Fetch origin → Pull origin.

First download of an existing project: Clone repository.

1. Install Git and GitHub Desktop

1. Download Git for Windows from the official site and run its installer. For ordinary use, the defaults are appropriate. GitHub Desktop also includes the Git functionality it needs.

2. Download and install GitHub Desktop from desktop.github.com.

3. Open GitHub Desktop and sign into your GitHub account. Create a GitHub account if you do not already have one.

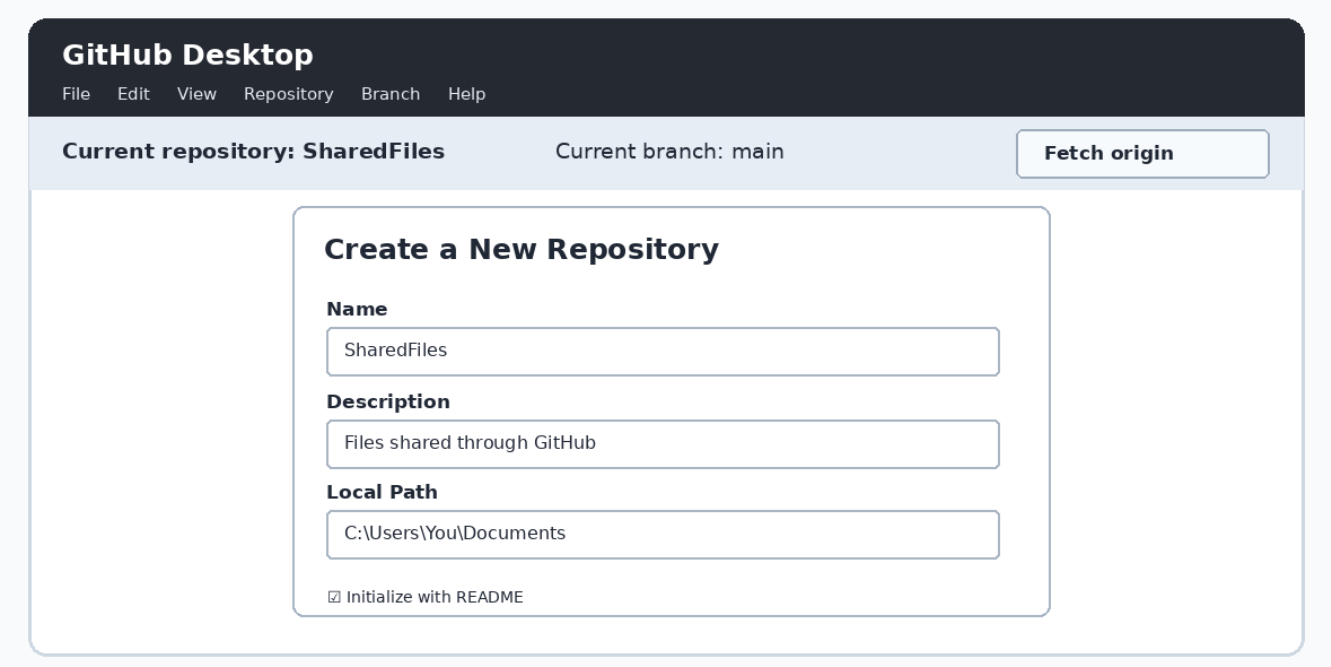
2. Create a new repository

1. Select **File** → **New repository**.

2. Enter a name, such as **SharedFiles**.

3. Choose a local parent folder and optionally initialize with a README.

4. Click **Create repository**.



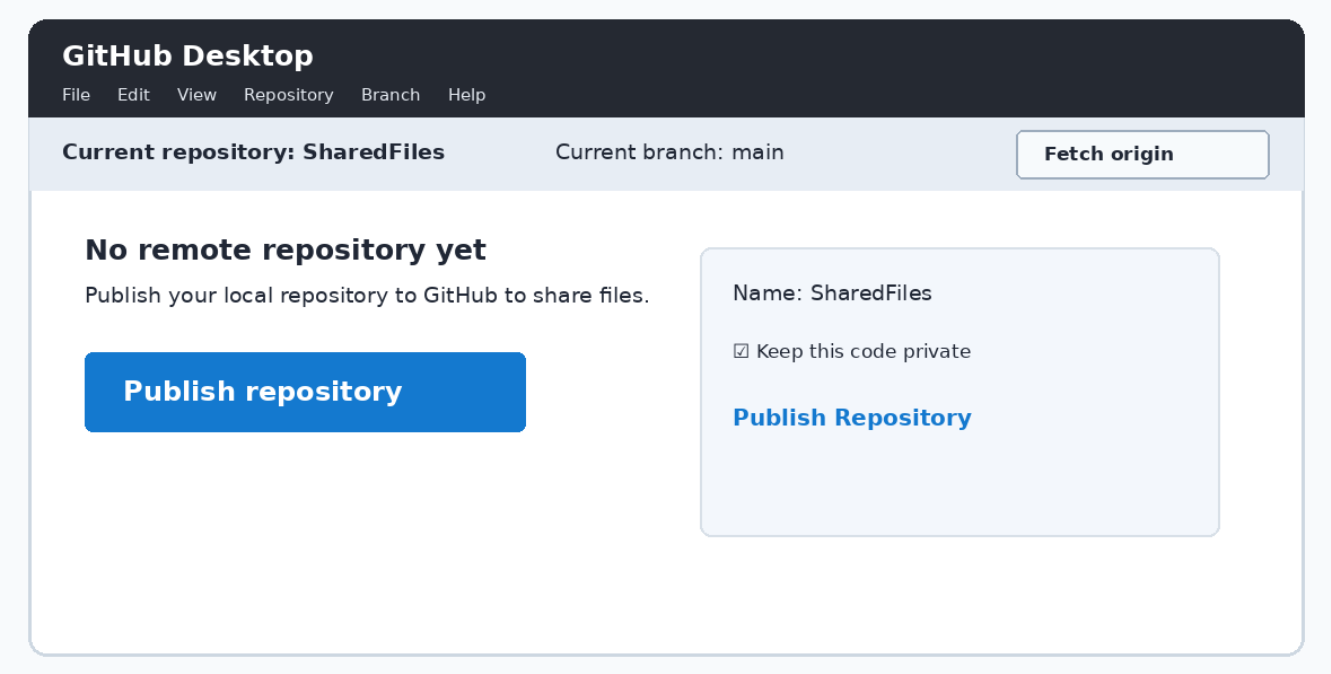
Illustrative GitHub Desktop screen (recreated for this guide; actual version may differ).

3. Publish the repository to GitHub

1. Select **Publish repository**.

2. Confirm the repository name, and choose private or public access.

3. Click **Publish Repository** to create the remote GitHub copy.



Illustrative GitHub Desktop screen (recreated for this guide; actual version may differ).

4. Upload files: commit and push

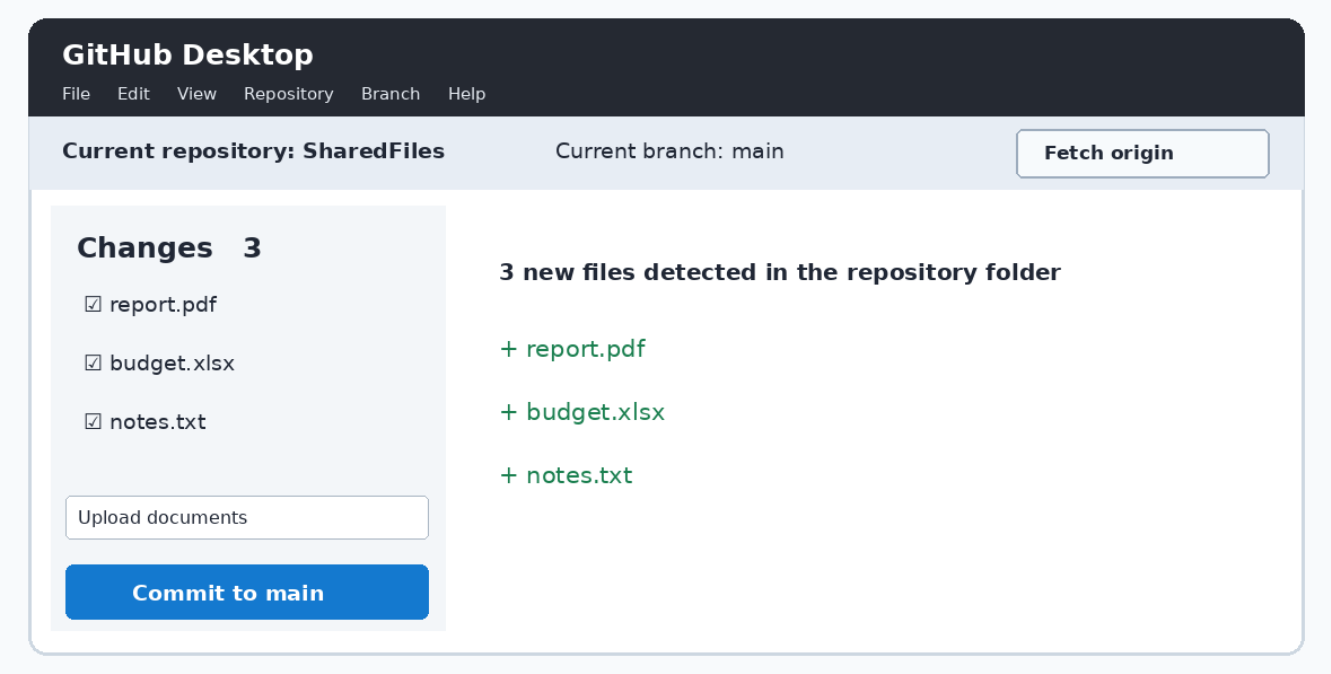
1. Select **Repository** → **Show in Explorer** to open the local repository folder.

2. Copy, drag, or paste your PDF, Excel, Word, image, or other files into that folder.

3. Return to GitHub Desktop and review the files listed under the **Changes** tab.

4. Enter a descriptive commit summary such as **Upload documents**.

5. Click **Commit to main** (or your branch name).

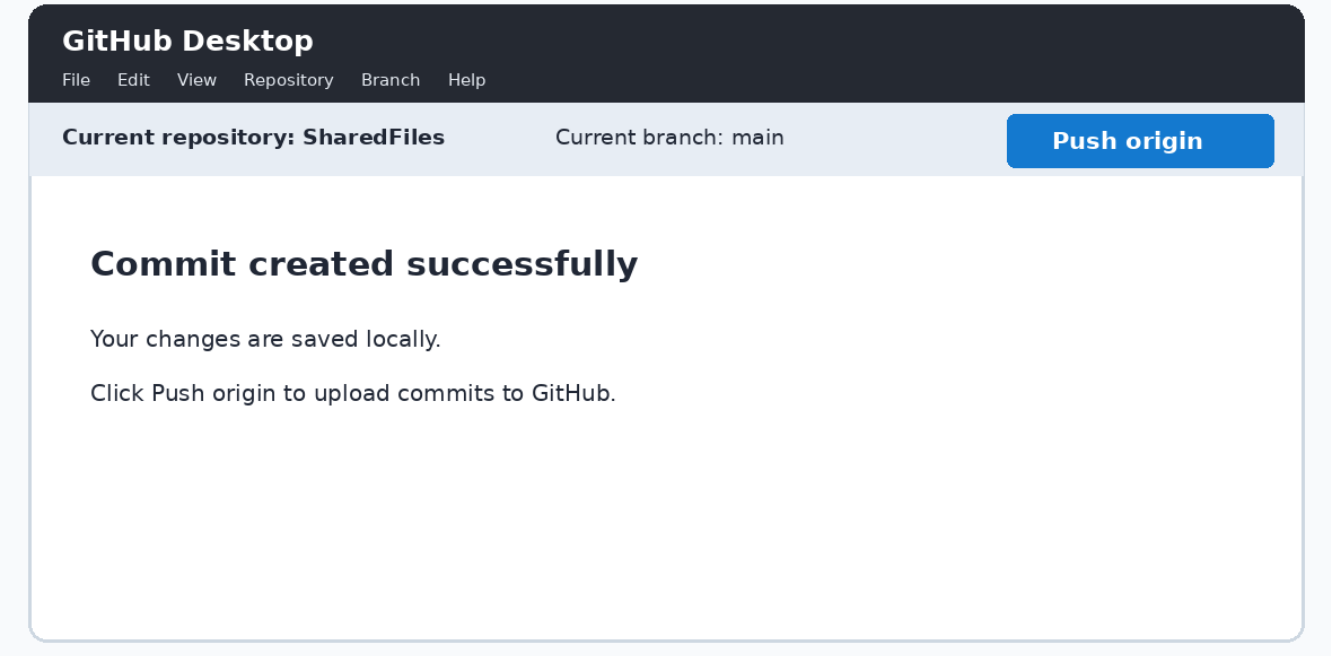


Illustrative GitHub Desktop screen (recreated for this guide; actual version may differ).

Commit saves a snapshot to local Git history. It does **not** upload changes to GitHub.

1. Click **Push origin**.

2. Select **Repository** → **View on GitHub** to verify the uploaded files.



Illustrative GitHub Desktop screen (recreated for this guide; actual version may differ).

5. Fetch and pull files

Fetch origin: Gets information about new remote commits without changing your current working files.

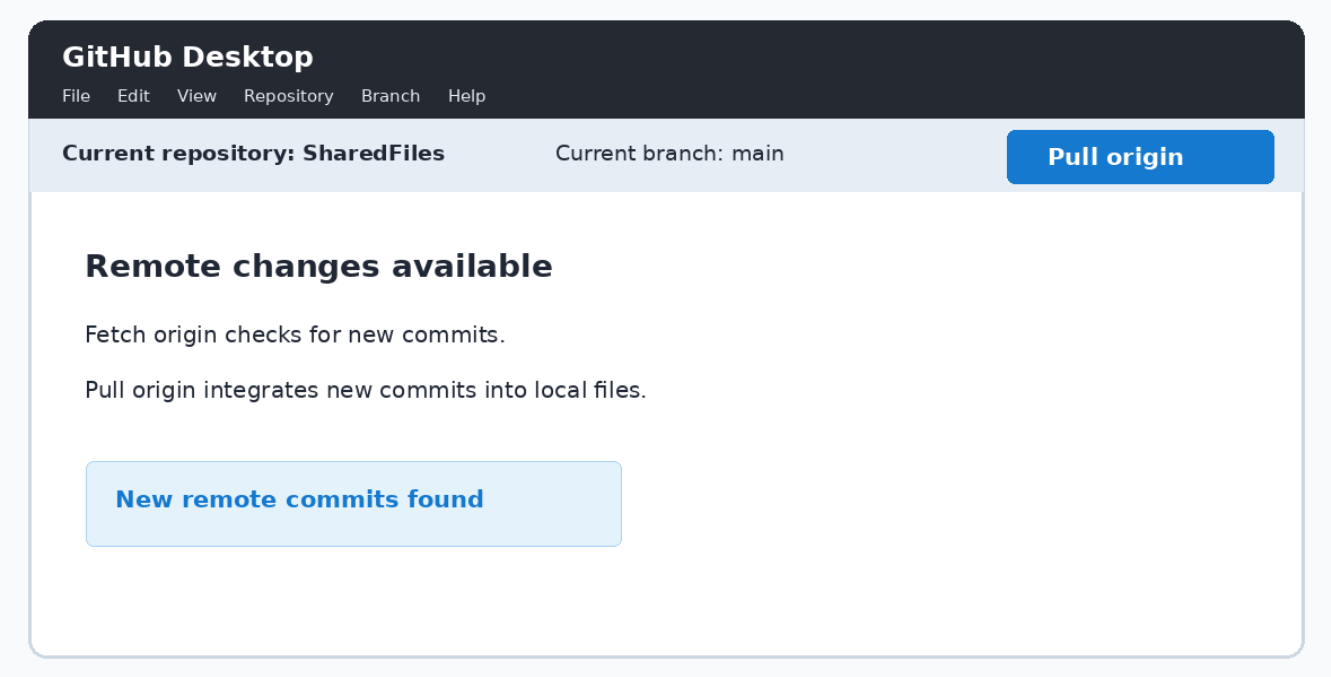
Pull origin: Fetches and integrates remote commits into your current local branch, updating files as appropriate.

Get the latest remote files

1. Select the correct repository and branch in GitHub Desktop.

2. Click **Fetch origin**. If there are new remote commits, GitHub Desktop will offer **Pull origin**.

3. Click **Pull origin**, then select **Repository** → **Show in Explorer** to view your updated files.



Illustrative GitHub Desktop screen (recreated for this guide; actual version may differ).

Practice example

1. On the GitHub website, add or edit a small text file and commit that change online.

2. On Windows, click **Fetch origin** in GitHub Desktop. Your working file does not change just from fetching.

3. Click **Pull origin**, then check the file in File Explorer.

6. Clone an existing repository

Clone is used once to download an existing repository to a new computer or a local folder.

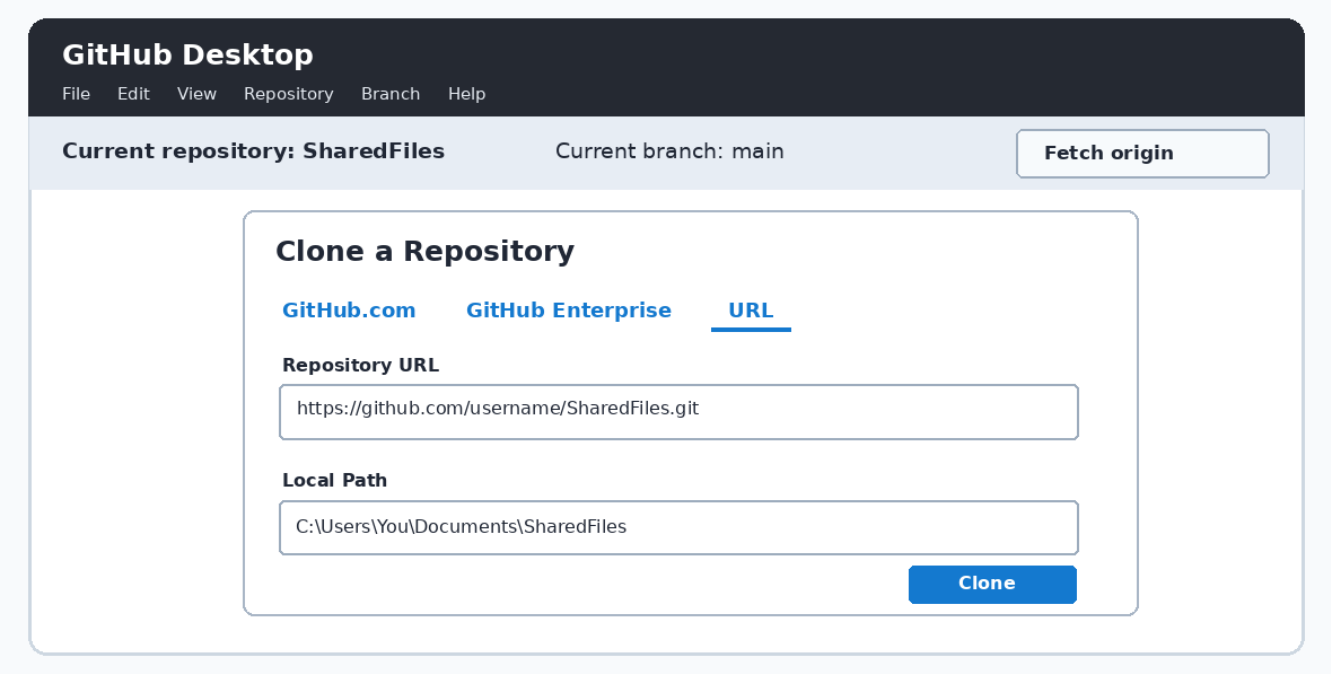
1. Open GitHub Desktop and choose **File** → **Clone repository**.

2. In the **GitHub.com** tab, pick a repository you can access, or select **URL** and paste its GitHub link.

3. Choose a local destination under **Local Path**.

4. Click **Clone**.

5. Select **Repository** → **Show in Explorer** to see the files.



Illustrative GitHub Desktop screen (recreated for this guide; actual version may differ).

Quick reference

Action	Meaning
Clone	Download an existing repository to this computer for the first time.
Fetch	Check/download remote history without integrating into your current branch.
Pull	Fetch and integrate remote changes into your local branch.
Commit	Save a snapshot of selected changes locally.
Push	Upload your local commits to GitHub.

Good habits: Keep sensitive files and passwords out of repositories; check repository and branch before pushing; commit or preserve unsaved local changes before pulling.

Reference: Official GitHub Desktop documentation.